Chapter 18

Return

Mountain - inside the Greater Seal

In Noxius

(Paul): — I need your account of the hearing. The sealed chamber, the five, the ruling. Will you begin with where you stood?

(Kailan): — No. Put the thing away. It fell three days since. It is falling still, Paul, on people who never heard our names. Who is left above to read how carefully we decided?

(Paul): — I cannot answer that. The reel keeps what the five said. It does not keep what you could see from the wall.

(Kailan): — You were in the room. Your machine ran the whole while. Ask the Keepers. Ask Sarah, ask Va-Sheva — they spoke. I stood with my hands bound and said almost nothing.

(Paul): — Va-Sheva refuses me; Sarah turns away; the Keepers are turning air and counting fish. I have asked them. At present I have my account, and I was occupied with the machine for much of it.

(Kailan): — I have a shift on the vents. Before it, I need to lie still. There is nothing in me to give you.

[—]

> (Paul): — Then leave the hearing. The road from Blackwood. Could you give me that?
>
> (Kailan): — … You kept the record. Give them the road yourself. I will take it up inside the Mountain. Paul. Let me rest.

I am Paul Morgan. This is my account of the return. My training is in strata, middens, worked flint and bone laid down in silt forty thousand years ago. The dates and intervals here come from the reel boxes and my notebooks. Where I stopped recording, I have used my memory; where I could not understand a speaker, I name the person who supplied the words.

At dusk I came down the steps of Blackwood with a coat, my notebooks and the travelling recorder. The dressing Kailan had put round my right hand caught under the carrying strap. I stopped to free it, and Va-Elise came back for me. The helicopter was turning. Behind her, doors I had never seen open admitted men carrying cases into the halls. Every window was lit.

At the house steps a man tried to give Sarah three files. She chose one and sent the other two back. Another asked what should become of the instruction rooms.

"Lock them. The instruction reels stay in Elise's fire case. Nothing else leaves except Mr Morgan's sealed interview reels and notebooks."

"The telephones?"

"Let them ring."

The travelling tape reached its clear leader before we boarded. I wrote the hour on the box, sealed the reel in its tin and gave it to Va-Elise. She set it with the sealed interviews, separate from the instruction boxes inside the fire case. The single route packet lay above them. I fitted the fresh spool she gave me while a crewman loaded Sarah's chair. Kailan stood beside the door until Sarah was aboard.

The house door remained open. A sheet of paper crossed the lawn, rose into the rotor wind and vanished over the roof.

The helicopter lifted in a lurch that put my stomach through my boots. For two years I had walked across the landing marks without seeing their whole outline. Sarah, ninety-three, spent the flight on a headset, making clipped calls in three languages. Her right thumb shook against the mouthpiece until she closed it beneath her left hand. She asked why the private aircraft was still on the ground, listened, and gave someone a number of minutes in which to correct that.

The headset passed to Va-Elise. I could hear her confirming fuel and vehicles; she used numbers for the places. Sarah took it back and called the outer stations separately. Two calls ended with a spoken acknowledgment. During the third she repeated a number, waited and wrote a small cross beside it. She began the

fourth with her pencil still against the page. I could not hear the replies through her earpiece.

Kailan sat opposite me. I kept the machine between my boots with its carrying strap around my wrist. Each time the helicopter banked, I drew it back against my ankles. Through the recorder's headset I heard our breath under the engine, Sarah's numbers, and the fire case's buckle tapping against Va-Elise's wrist. She put a finger between buckle and case. The tapping stopped.

The helicopter put us down at Geneva beside the private aircraft. We waited in an old freight hangar. When the clearance lamp turned green, Urs remained behind the red line and we boarded. I had flown to digs in the cargo netting of transports older than myself and had never entered such a cabin. There were beds and a shower. Food arrived through a door I failed to notice, and I ate all of it. Kailan touched nothing. He watched the window. Sarah ate half a piece of toast and slept upright. Once she opened her eyes. "Finish your meal, Mr Morgan. I do not know when any of us will eat properly again." Then she shut them again.

Va-Elise worked at the table with three maps that did not join. On the first she marked the aircraft's descent. On the second she marked the road the vehicles were to take. The third began where the road failed and contained no destination, only wells and strips of stone. I asked which of the wells still answered to Horizon. Va-Elise put her finger beside one.

"We meet Amastan here. He tells us which wells we can use."

"And if he does not come?" I asked.

Sarah opened her eyes. "Keep them under cover. Nobody goes looking. If Amastan cannot reach his own meeting place, we have no safe road past it. Keep enough fuel to take the drivers back."

Va-Elise wrote below the map and folded the three separately. I lay down. Kailan was already asleep. We flew through the night; I woke as we began our descent.

At dawn we came down onto old colonial tarmac. Lamps stood in jars along the broken edge; a broom lay beside the last jar. Beyond them were a windsock, two fuel drums and three black armoured vehicles with their engines turning. Jean-Charles came from the middle vehicle to meet us. Kailan spoke his name and raised a hand. Va-Elise gave the drivers their maps. None was asked to name the destination.

A tall blonde woman stood beside the driver's door, her hair cropped above her ears, a fitted black shirt tucked into her field trousers. She handed Va-Elise a roll of satellite prints.

Men in work clothes unloaded water, cloth, medical cases and sacks of feed. Weapons came last. Jean-Charles opened a long case across a quiet man's knees, inspected what lay inside and closed it without removing anything.

Sarah refused the chair. She descended the aircraft steps with Kailan one pace below her and Va-Elise behind, and stood at the bottom until her breathing settled. Then she asked the drivers whether anyone had approached the strip. One had seen lights beyond the pan. Another had heard an engine and no aircraft. She assigned the first report to the lead vehicle and the second to the rear.

"Alice. Do you remember the route to the first stop?" Va-Elise asked.

"My name is Alice, and I remember everything."

Jean-Charles laughed. "She's been saving that one."

Alice named the turns and the stopping place, then clipped the map beside her wheel.

"You keep the route," Sarah told her. "Changes come through Elise or me. When the vehicles turn back, you stay with us."

Va-Elise took the lead. Alice drove the middle vehicle, with Jean-Charles beside her; Sarah, Kailan and I were strapped behind him, with the quiet man and his cased weapon in the rear seat. The third held our tail. Before we moved, Va-Elise passed the fire case through our window and Kailan braced it between his boots.

The sun cleared the horizon as we left the tarmac. Jean-Charles used no map. At each fork he waited for Va-Elise's rear lamp to show once and disappear. Alice checked each turning against the map clipped beside the wheel. Sarah held the station book closed on her knees.

They ran a straight strip of tar across the pan at a speed that shook speech out of us. A knot of vehicles appeared far to the east. Va-Elise's rear lamps showed. Jean-Charles turned in his seat; behind me a catch opened and the long case touched my elbow. The distant vehicles crossed behind us. No one fired. Jean-Charles watched them diminish in his mirror, then gave Alice two fingers forward.

At the next rise the lead vehicle left the road without warning. We followed it down a dry drainage cut, the armour striking stone under my feet. The third vehicle continued along the tar. Through the rear slit I watched its dust pass the rise and disappear. Jean-Charles held one hand against the roof. Alice stopped. An engine sounded above us, dwindled, then another followed it. We stayed in

the cut until our rear vehicle appeared behind us. Jean-Charles lowered his hand and Va-Elise moved again.

Beyond the pan the tar ended. We went slowly over broken ground, stopping twice for the other crews to change drivers with the engines still running. The quiet man slept with one hand through the case handle. Jean-Charles woke him after forty minutes and gave him the forward seat. Through the rear glass I watched our own dust; when the wind cleared it, the track was empty.

Near the end of the track stood one of Sarah's stations. On the aircraft she had described the buried rooms: two or three people, a drum, a border and a fuel gauge. The door of this one stood open to the desert.

Sarah stayed outside while Jean-Charles went in. He called us after him. She stopped with her hand against the frame.

"They had orders to keep this shut. Direct clearance for every visitor."

Three enamel cups stood beside a kettle. Cool air came from the wall and water ran from the tap. Blood had dried on the floor and the table lip. There were no bodies. On the back of a stores request someone had written a message. The pencil lay in the page gutter. I held the recorder over the table and read the last legible words: *door opened with*.

The next letter was a downward stroke. Blood lay under the writer's side of the page. None crossed the words. Beside the inner door were three hooks and a duty board bearing three names. One chair lay on its side. Another had been driven against the table hard enough to split its back rail. The chair before the drum held the dark print of a hand, with four separate fingertips along the edge.

Sarah examined the outer door. I held the lamp while she turned its edge toward her. There was no split wood, no bent hinge, no scoring around the lock. She closed it, opened it again with the key and kept the key in her palm.

Va-Elise went outside to examine the approach. Jean-Charles checked the rear room, the generator recess and the duct wide enough for an arm. I could hear each small door open from where I stood at the table. In the corner a record box had burned. The leaves along its edges were black; the middle of the files remained brown and readable.

The drum kept turning. Five strokes came up from the ground beneath us and drew themselves on its paper. Kailan stood before them without touching the sheet. They were evenly spaced, with the same rise. When the fifth ended, the stylus went back to its thin, irregular line. Sarah watched the interval and checked her wristwatch.

"Again in forty minutes," she said. "These are the same five strokes. Same height, same spacing. They are sounding on a programme."

Whole files had been pressed into the record box. Its lid had charred on the inside. Beneath the black scales of the outer leaves, paper remained the colour of old tea. I lifted the sheets in their order and spoke their dates. Fuel. Water. Watch changes. A delivery entered four weeks before and cancelled in another hand. The corner crumbled between my forceps and left a black crescent on the table. I moved the machine out of the falling ash. The first lines of the stores request reported the same five-stroke signal.

Va-Elise called us to the entrance. She showed Sarah a length of pale thread, then pointed out the heavier tread over earlier prints in the dust. Two sets continued away from the door. Beside them a scuff became parallel heel cuts. Beyond the rise she had photographed tyre marks. I could follow the marks once she placed my eye above them; I could not assign them to the names on the board.

"Taken, probably," Sarah said. "We act on the chance that they are alive. Three people who can read my notation and show where these lines are buried. None can give another station's location, but these instruments and their own approaches will be enough to begin with." She put her hand on the table until the shaking stopped. "Elise. If anyone has them, I want them back."

She read the three names from the duty board into the recorder. After each name she gave an office, years of service and the person to whom news should be carried if there remained anyone able to carry it. On the third she had to look back at the board before she could give the years.

Va-Elise found the route drawer unlocked and empty. Sarah checked its label: this station's access and withdrawal papers. She returned to the entrance and examined the undamaged lock.

"A visitor they admitted?" I asked.

"Possibly. Or someone with a key. Or someone they opened to under threat. Record the condition of the lock. We have no witness to the opening."

She opened her own station book beside the empty drawer and worked down a page of call signs with the scorched pencil. Six received a cross. Va-Elise copied those six onto a separate list, read them back and waited for the order.

"Those share outside support with this post," Sarah said. "Go back with the vehicles. Have each cell recalled separately through the central office, by its own cleared channel. No resupply on these roads. People first; break the instruments they cannot carry."

"Blackwood?" Va-Elise asked.

"The address is known. No one goes back to it. Use the withdrawal arrangements. Do not wait for another order from me."

"And if one of the six has already opened?"

Sarah put the station key into her palm. "Bring out whom you can. Burn what has to stay. Open the files before you put a flame to them."

Va-Elise closed her fingers over the key. She put the list inside her sleeve and went out to the drivers. I held the machine low while Sarah repeated the third name and corrected the years. The generator ticked behind the wall. Wind lifted the edge of the unfinished message against its pencil.

Outside someone called for hands to carry water. I closed the machine's lid and went to the door with it hanging from my wrist. A man waited while I shifted the strap high enough to take the other handle of his tin.

The next five strokes began while we were carrying the water out. All of us stopped. Dust moved in the split of the table. The kettle gave a small metallic answer. Sarah counted the interval aloud, then told us to keep moving.

The vehicles stopped where the track entered folded rock. A young man waited there with two others and eight animals, his face bound against the glare. Sarah called him Amastan.

He counted us and our loads before he answered her. He rejected two water tins because their caps rang against the handles, wrapped the recorder's metal catches in felt and divided the documents from the food. His companions repacked each animal by touch in the shade of the folds. One unfastened a bundle Va-Elise had tied and put its heavier half against the saddle. Amastan tested it with his knee. When nothing metal could strike metal, he uncovered his face.

"My grandfather carried that name for you," he said. "He has been thirty years in the ground. I carry it now." He drew the last strap through its ring. "Your officers put that name in their treaties before my grandfather was born. They spelled it wrong."

Va-Elise opened a map on the bonnet of the lead vehicle. Amastan looked once, drew a different line in the dust with the butt of his switch and put three stones across the route she had marked.

"That road was safe when my father held the name. It has tyre cuts now. Men watched it two nights ago." He moved the line west through a blank place on her map. "We go here."

Jean-Charles crouched beside the drawing. Amastan tapped each turn with his switch and made him repeat it. At the third, Jean-Charles pointed farther north.

Amastan tapped the same place again. Jean-Charles named it. Amastan erased the whole with his foot.

Va-Elise put the tactical packet into Jean-Charles's hand. "This sector and two abort points," she said. "No onward route." She pointed to Amastan, who had begun checking the animal loads. "From here, ask him."

She opened the fire case and put my sealed interview reels and the travelling tins into a felt wrap. The instruction boxes and route papers stayed with her. She placed the wrap in my hands and waited while I tied it shut.

"No house behind us, Mr Morgan. Keep these dry."

She collected the drivers' maps and returned to the lead vehicle. The quiet man took Alice's place at the wheel. Alice put her water and rolled prints into a saddlebag beside mine. No return route passed to Jean-Charles. At the first open ground the vehicles divided: one north, one east, one back toward the old tarmac. Amastan stood beside Sarah's animal until the three dust lines had thinned beyond sight. Then he shifted her saddle one hole and gave the word to move.

We set out at night and lay under ground-coloured cloth by day. Amastan chose the hours, the wells and the order of drinking. The animals drank before us.

The first night was stone underfoot and a wind that filled the recorder's catches with grit. Amastan walked ahead of the first animal without a light. One of his companions walked last and brushed the places where a hoof slipped. Jean-Charles twice offered a bearing. Amastan heard him and continued along his own line. At the next halt he retied the felt around my machine. The thread had worked loose where I kept putting my thumb beneath it to reach the switch.

By the second night I could tell a halt from a concealment. At a halt, the animals lowered their heads and someone checked the loads. At concealment, Amastan raised one closed hand and no buckle moved. Once we remained that way while an engine passed beyond the ridge. Its vibration came first through the soles of my boots. I held the recorder against my coat; the engine became audible and passed out of hearing before Amastan lowered his hand.

We reached a well before dawn, a crack at the back of a cleft. Amastan removed six fitted slabs, drew water with a skin narrow enough to pass between them, watered the animals and replaced the slabs in reverse order. His companion brushed the rock with a branch. When they had finished, I could not find the opening from three paces away.

"Does the Mountain keep this well?" I asked.

"My people keep it."

I pointed to a pale edge on one of the slabs. "That has been cut recently."

"My sister's son. The old stone split in the cold." He coiled the wet line against his arm. "He carried that one here."

Sarah rode in a sling they fitted around the saddle. At ninety-three she could still mount on the first night. By the third, Amastan and Kailan had to lift her. She allowed it without speaking. At noon her hand shook against the rim of her cup. I set the machine between my knees and held the cup while she drank. When it was empty she said, "Mr Morgan, if that appears in your account, at least spell my name correctly."

"I always do."

"One useful quality."

Amastan shortened the next passage. He moved the longest climb into the coldest hour and put Kailan at the left side of Sarah's animal, where the ground fell away. Sarah caught the guide's sleeve before he could go ahead.

"We have already lost half a day."

He looked down at her hand. "You could not lift your foot into the sling."

"I have crossed this country since before your father was born."

"Then let him hold you on the climb." Amastan waited. Sarah released his sleeve and put her hand on the saddle.

We left at the hour he had chosen. On the third night he stopped at a cairn and counted its stones with his switch. "One has been added," he said. He left it standing and took us six hours around.

At the next halt Kailan called the folds the Mountain's outer wall, the last country no state had crossed. Amastan had the end of a load strap between his teeth. He drew it tight, fastened it and came round the animal to face Kailan.

"Whose men changed that cairn?" he asked.

Kailan looked back along the fold. "I do not know."

"Nor do I. That is why we walked around." Amastan picked up his switch. "Your Mountain may call this its wall. Ask it who keeps the wells."

Kailan moved back to the left of Sarah's animal. During the daylight hides I recorded speech. At night I let the machine turn for a few minutes at each change of ground: soft hoof-fall on sand, iron striking buried stone, wind through a slit too narrow to see. Then I stopped it and wrote the hour on the band around the reel. I numbered every interval I did not record. When I opened the battery compartment, Amastan held a corner of the ground-cloth over my hands until I had shut it again.

On the fourth night the five strokes reached us without paper or instrument. I felt the first through my feet. Sarah's animal raised its head. Four more followed at equal distances, too low to hear and distinct through the ground. Amastan put his fingers to the rock. Sarah counted. We covered the metal fittings, gave the animals the final water and went forward on foot.

We reached the camp overlook in the last dark of the fourth night. Amastan's companions took the animals into a high cleft while he brought us up through a dry wash and stopped us below its rim. He pressed a palm to the ground.

"From there onward, their instruments can hear a stone roll."

He took Jean-Charles forward on his belly. When they returned, Jean-Charles asked him to repeat the passage between two listening posts. Amastan traced the first turns against the rock.

"At the last bend you go alone. If they see me, they will watch the way I came."

Jean-Charles removed his coat, covered the pale skin of his hands and face, and tightened the cloth at his collar. He saw me watching.

"Still taking notes on me, professor?"

"Your questions at the safe house are on the record. So is your request that Kailan keep them from Elise."

He pulled the cloth across his mouth. "And Sarah heard him tell it. She still asked me to get her through their posts."

"That is on the record too."

"Good. Keep the machine dry."

Amastan led him over the rim and came back alone. I heard nothing from Jean-Charles before the light came.

Grey light entered the pan while we lay against cold rock. Dishes, tents and parked vehicles separated from the ground. Beyond them stood the drilling rig. Two pale flecks crossed the sky without sound. Alice watched them, checked her watch and gave Amastan the next times she expected overhead coverage. A dish beside the command tents turned slowly and stopped. I kept my face below the rim.

Through the glass I saw men on the ridges facing inward, with tripods among them pointed into the rock. Survey stakes made straight red lines across the pan. Alice spread her latest print beneath the glass and marked two posts absent from it. Sarah named a western truck's position as the northern mouth of an old drovers' track to the Oasis. Shield had allowed it to pass out of use, she said; no Outsider was supposed to know where that mouth lay.

"They were told," Kailan said.

"I think so." Sarah pointed below the rig. "West of your Hall. What lies deeper along that line?"

"The reserve."

"Water?"

He nodded.

A double ring of tents occupied the camp's centre. Generator housings stood beside it, and men were loading stretchers into long vehicles. I watched an orderly carry a folded blanket past the inner cordon. Armed men at its entrance kept a truck waiting while its driver showed a paper. I handed the glass back.

Sarah kept her eye to it. "A good half of what you see was written in my hand." She followed the orderly until he went inside a tent.

"Some part of me wanted the Mountain found. I wanted not to be the last one holding it." She lowered the glass into the space between us.

We waited through the daylight. Amastan pulled cloth over the hollow behind our ledge and weighted it without raising an edge above the rock. Sarah lay beneath it. Whenever he brought her water, she asked whether Jean-Charles had returned. He shook his head and let her drink. Alice lay across the mouth of our hollow with the glass on the wash. I kept the recorder in the shade and my notebook against my chest, where the wind could not turn its pages.

Men replaced one another at the posts. A line formed outside the cooking tents and broke apart; vehicles moved between the rig and stacked lengths of pipe. Heat shook the space above them until I could no longer keep a man's outline in the glass. When the shadow reached our ledge again, Sarah sat up without help.

We heard no shot. Late in the day, Jean-Charles appeared in the wash with a man bent in front of him. Amastan went down to meet them, placing their steps as they climbed. The prisoner wore the camp's grey clothes. His wrists were bound; a gag held his mouth. Jean-Charles carried a flat hard case and a black field radio.

"Post nine," he said. "The seam is open beyond it. Not for long."

He put the case on the rock between us. Sarah bent over the catches. I brought the recorder beside her hand.

"Before you open it. Where did you take it from, Jean-Charles?"

"A locked drawer in the command tent."

Sarah kept her fingers on the catches. "How long, Mr Morgan?"

"Long enough to identify him and the condition in which it reached us. His access is part of the examination."

She took her hand away. “Do it.”

I gave the hour, described the place and both catches, and stated Jean-Charles’s name. He repeated where he had found the case and said no one else had handled it since. I had seen him come up the wash carrying it; his account supplied the earlier custody. I opened it beside the recorder, keeping the lid toward the camp so the paper would not show white above the rock.

The papers carried one stock, one sequence of punch holes and consecutive issue marks. Corrections on separate sheets had been made in the same ink and impressed the leaves beneath them. I held two pages against the light to match an impression, then placed them back in order.

“The leaves were together when these corrections were made,” I said. “I cannot certify their contents.”

Sarah found a small mark in the upper corner of the first sheet.

“French strategic service. A compartment descended from the arrangements Martinez and my father made in this desert. The mineral company is a cover. This is a state operation.”

She set that sheet face up inside the lid and began translating the French into the Mountain’s language. The next leaves carried a joint Algerian groundwater and rare-earth concession; she read the number, drilling permits and customs entries and judged them genuine. A distribution table allocated fuel, airspace and explosives approvals to separate offices and survey blocks. The central coordinates appeared in none of the Algerian recipients’ copies listed there. A personnel annex counted three thousand and eighty-four people across nine contractors: drilling, transport, aviation, medicine, camp labour and security. It listed three hundred and eighty-six French service numbers. I checked the addition of its subtotals.

Sarah read the operational headings and pointed to the corresponding parts of the camp: seismic sounding, bore depths and dates, capture medicine, water control, approach denial, compartmented command. At the last she went back to the distribution table.

“The drilling and the concessions will survive inspection. Each office can show its own permits. None needs to see this page.”

Kailan leaned across the case. “What do they know of the mechanism?”

“That there is one. These are orders to reach it. My grid, my methods.” She held the page at its lower corners. “They have not written down what they expect it to do.”

Three leaves into the logistics annex, I found the local name Sarah had used for the northern track. It stood among forty routes. Sarah translated the entry beside it: *source: internal, reliability high*.

I gave her the page and touched the line.

"After Martinez was shut out, who held that corridor?"

"One channel." She kept the page on the rock between us.

"Jean-Charles?"

"Yes."

"The entry does not name him. And he brought us the case."

She folded the page once. "Keep that qualification in your account. I am keeping this."

She put it inside her coat. Jean-Charles stood beside the prisoner, watching the wash. He had asked us no question about the papers. I stopped the machine while we read the remaining leaves. By my watch the gap was four minutes. I put the service-marked first sheet back over the others, started the reel and stated the times and reason for the gap.

The field radio lit. A young voice spoke French. Jean-Charles covered the set until the light died. Sarah translated: post nine had missed its check; if Farid had crawled behind a rock to sleep again, he could answer to the sergeant.

Amastan cut the gag. The prisoner raised his head when Sarah repeated Farid's name. Amastan held the water skin for him because his wrists were tied behind his back. Water ran into the hollow above his collar; when Amastan lowered the skin, Farid bent after it. Amastan let him drink again.

Sarah put our questions to him in French and gave us his replies. He said he guarded a mineral survey. He knew his own watch and the two posts beside it. He had been told there were "primitives" underground, a lost tribe to be handled *without loss of life*. Sappers were to preserve what they found intact.

Kailan crouched where Farid could see his face. Sarah stayed beside them to translate.

"Who told you to take no life?" Kailan asked.

"A medical officer. I do not know his name."

"The same officer who sets the charges?"

"No."

"Who can stop the digging?"

"Operations. Not our command."

"Who among you may speak to the men on the western ridge?"

Farid looked toward it. "No one at my post. They have their own command."

Kailan drew the case toward his knees. Sarah found the live-capture orders and translated the five priorities, each coded by task with the name omitted. He stopped her at three and repeated them in his own words: the one who reads the deep water; the one who keeps the hours; the one who holds the seal. Sarah pointed to the other two entries and gave him their wording again.

"Read those to him," he said.

Sarah did. Farid shook his head at each. He tried to lean away from the case; his bound hands caught against the rock.

"Five functions," Kailan said to Sarah. "They want all five alive. Put them together under guard and make them work it."

"Can they?" Sarah asked.

Kailan kept the page between his hands. "That is what the division is meant to prevent."

Farid looked from Kailan to Sarah. She had stopped translating. He pulled his wrists against the binding and looked again at the water skin.

The radio spoke again, in a lower voice. "The sergeant," Sarah said. Lights came on at two posts.

"The road is open," Jean-Charles said. "Amastan knows a seam beyond post nine their instruments do not yet cover. Farid's missed check has shortened our hour to minutes."

One of Amastan's companions moved Farid's bindings to the front and led him into the high cleft. He carried the water skin with them. "We keep him until your road is shut," Amastan said. "Then he goes."

Kailan put the page back and closed the case. Jean-Charles took its handle, put it into Sarah's hand and gave me the field radio. "We go now."

We left the animals, blankets and empty water skins in the high cleft. I put the reel tins inside my coat and bound the recorder against my chest with its carrying strap. Sarah tried the station book inside her coat. Its spine kept her elbow out from her body. Kailan took the hard case while she lay flat and tried to draw the arm beneath her. She got up and tore out the crossed page of call signs. She took the annex from her coat and put both leaves inside her sleeve. Kailan gave her back the case. The book remained under a stone.

Amastan led us to the rim. Three lights moved along the wash Jean-Charles had used; another swept the ridge above post nine. Men called in pairs. The drilling continued beneath them, a regular iron turning that covered smaller sounds and then stopped without warning. Each time it stopped, we stopped with it.

At the first turn Amastan placed our feet in his own marks. At the second he took Sarah's weight across a slab that sounded hollow when my knee touched it. At the third he pointed to a black cut no wider than a doorway.

"That cut reaches the old seam," he said. "I stop here."

Sarah touched Alice's sleeve. "Stay with Amastan. Keep the way back open."

Alice checked the cut, then turned to watch the ridge behind us. "Go."

Sarah gripped his wrist. "Close the northern well."

"It was closed before you came."

"The other two?"

"My brother takes one. My sister takes the other."

He looked at Kailan. "Tell Shield who is closing them. Tell them the northern road has tyre cuts. They will have to ask us before they send anyone that way again."

Kailan repeated the message. Amastan listened to the end, then withdrew over our path, lifting the marks with a brush of hide. Alice went after him, stopping at the turn until we had reached the cut.

Jean-Charles entered the cut first, Sarah behind him, Kailan behind her, and I last. We moved on elbows where the roof came down. The radio against my ribs gave one burst of French through its cloth. Kailan's foot stopped beside my hand. Ahead, Sarah whispered, "Eight through twelve. Close the western arc. Find Farid."

I worked the set out of its wrapping and passed it to Kailan. He slid it along the rock beside Sarah; she pushed it into Jean-Charles's waiting hand. He turned a control and the voice vanished.

"Did you answer?" Sarah whispered.

"No."

"Could you have?"

"I know the language of the post. I do not know the man's alarm word."

He set it on the rock for Sarah. She kept her hand beside his until he released it, then passed it back through Kailan. I wrapped it against my ribs with the control facing away from me. Sarah drew the case forward, pushed it flat and crawled after it.

The cut opened above a slope of broken shale. Across it stood post nine: two men, a low tent and a tripod turning by degrees. Beyond the post, the ground met the Mountain in an unbroken face. I could see no seam. A white lamp moved along the base of the rock, withdrew and returned.

Jean-Charles counted the tripod's turns with one finger. On the fifth he took us across. For twelve paces the shale shifted under every knee. We placed each stone in the space the hand ahead had left. Sarah's breath became audible. Kailan stopped and drew her arm across his shoulders. The tripod turned away. We moved again.

A voice challenged from the post. Jean-Charles put us flat and answered in French. I have no French, and he was not loud. The voice asked a second question. He gave a shorter reply. A man stepped beyond the tent and raised his lamp toward us. At that moment the drilling rig began again. Jean-Charles pulled Sarah to her feet and ran bent beneath her arm. Kailan took her other side. I went after them with the recorder striking my ribs. When I looked back, the lamp crossed the place where we had lain. Small stones were still rolling down from it.

The rock face remained whole until Jean-Charles put his hand into a shadow below it. His arm disappeared to the wrist. Kailan knelt, cleared three handfuls of gravel and uncovered a narrow bronze plate with five shallow cups. He pressed the outer two, the centre, then the outer two again. Nothing moved.

Jean-Charles kept his shoulder at the stone. "Nothing."

"The return sign changes with the hour," Kailan said. He held his fingers above the cups.

Sarah drew her feet clear of his knees. "You have room. Try."

Kailan set the pattern a second time and held the centre cup. Jean-Charles leaned harder against the stone. A line opened without sound. Cold air came through it. Two hands reached from the dark. Sarah passed the case to Kailan and took the hands; they pulled her inside. He passed the case through and followed it. Jean-Charles caught my coat at the shoulder and pushed me after him.

The white lamp found the bronze plate as he entered. A shot struck the rock above the opening. The hands inside pulled him clear; the seam closed on a fall of dust. No weapon answered from within.

For several breaths I heard our breathing and the recorder turning under my coat. Someone close to me coughed. Then a lamp was uncovered.

Va-Sheva stood beside the uncovered lamp in Shield grey. The chamber was low enough that Jean-Charles remained bent until he had stepped clear of the seam. Two wardens held us along one wall. Kailan picked up the case just inside the seam and gave it back to Sarah. Va-Sheva looked from it to the radio in my hands, then to the recorder under my coat. She sent one warden to the seam and

kept the other between us and the inner door. She was with child; her belt lay above the swelling.

The inner warden searched us while the other held the seam. Sarah showed the folded pages in her sleeve and laid the case at her feet. Kailan carried no weapon. I put down the field radio and drew my coat clear of the recorder. The warden reached for its strap.

"Your name and office, please," I said. "If you take it, I must record the transfer."

Va-Sheva caught his wrist. He let the strap fall against my chest. He went on to Jean-Charles, who laid down a pistol, two knives, a length of black cord and three objects I could not name.

"It stays closed," she said. "Shield will hear what it contains with Justice present, or destroy it with the man who carried it."

The warden wrapped the field radio and hard case separately and set them in a stone recess without opening either. Sarah returned the folded pages to her sleeve. Blood from the shale had soaked through one knee of her trousers. Va-Sheva pointed to it.

"After the hearing," Sarah said.

"Bind it while she speaks," Va-Sheva told the warden. "If she falls, carry her. Do not stop her answer."

The warden knelt to bind Sarah's knee. Va-Sheva faced Kailan across the lamp.

"You were sent to find whether the enemy within was real. You were to report through me. You have brought two Outsiders before the five could hear them, and a machine carrying our speech, through a seam no Veil is shown. Your errand did not authorise any of that. By the law I hold, I should kill you here and close the stone over all four."

Kailan looked at the warden by the seam. "Then hear the finding before you carry out the law. You are the ear they gave me."

"I am listening."

"The men outside mean to take the five alive. Sarah has their orders. The bore is aimed below the Hall. Hear her measure."

Sarah held her leg still under the warden's hands. "My methods brought them this far. I can show Shield what they are doing with them."

Va-Sheva faced her. "How deep?"

Sarah gave the measure. Va-Sheva asked the angle, the number of rigs and the interval between the five strokes. Sarah answered each. The warden pulled the bandage tight; she stopped on a number, then gave it again.

Va-Sheva turned to Jean-Charles. “You brought them through the outer posts?”

“Yes. They have challenged us. The seam was seen.”

She looked at his empty hands. “I trust your hands. I have worked beside them. You remain with us.” When the inner warden had tied Sarah’s bandage, she sent him to summon Shield and Justice, then pointed to my recorder. “That remains on you, Outsider. If it opens, you die before the lid clears.”

“Understood,” I said.

“Under necessity of Shield, I admit the four of you as far as the sealed floor and no farther. Justice will decide whether the five hear you. The seam you used is dead from this hour. I answer for the admission.”

The warden at the seam drove a bronze pin into the five-cup plate. Three descending blows sounded inside the wall. The pin’s head was flattened against the bronze. He took his hammer away. Va-Sheva waited for the last sound to stop, then lifted the lamp. Sarah tried her weight on the bound knee. Jean-Charles took her uninjured side, Kailan the other. I followed them towards the inner door.

Wardens met us beyond it. Va-Sheva sent one back to guard the radio and hard case in their recess. At the crossings she stopped others with a low word; one went downward and another ran ahead. Sarah kept pace beside the lamp, answering Va-Sheva’s questions.

“How many bores?”

“Three active. One deep. Two shallow.”

“How much time?”

“The case gives a date for reaching the Hall. Have it brought to Justice. I cannot certify how closely they have kept the schedule.”

“Can you stop it from this side?”

“Not by meeting the bit. You may collapse a throat ahead of it, if you know the rock and can lose the chambers beyond. You may foul a water bore, but then you lose the water. You may let them enter a false void and close it behind them. I need a survey before I can tell you which.”

Va-Sheva sent for the keepers of the north-western galleries and the oldest survey kept by Stone. She asked whether the deep reserve shared a wall with the lower wards. Sarah said her earlier route had not shown her those galleries. At the next crossing a warden brought a black marking stone. Sarah drew the ridge, rig and angle on the passage wall. Kailan placed the Hall and held the stone below it.

“The reserve is deeper,” he said. “I cannot give you its depth.”

Va-Sheva studied the marks, sent another message to Stone and wiped the drawing away with her sleeve. Black dust remained in the folds of the grey cloth.

"Justice will require the order of discovery," she told Kailan. "What you saw, what she measured, what the papers say. Keep those separate. I shall give the five Shield's reason for admitting you. I cannot give them yours."

"I will give it. Bring the case."

"With its guard. It will be opened before Justice."

Where the stair turned, Sarah and Jean-Charles had gone several steps ahead. Va-Sheva lowered her voice. I was one step behind Kailan with the recorder against my ribs.

"Elise wrote that you did not speak for eleven days at the house. Is it true?"

"Yes."

"Could you drink?"

"When she put the cup in my hands."

"Sleep?"

"Not enough."

Va-Sheva raised the lamp to see the next step. "I would have ordered the containment again."

Kailan stayed below her. She lowered the lamp a little.

"Do not ask me for more tonight," she said. "I need to keep you alive long enough to answer them."

She climbed after the others. Kailan waited until the space of one step had opened between them, then followed.

The route crossed an open stair above the common wards. Lamps burned over food stalls. A woman walked twelve children in pairs; the smallest held the back of the child's tunic ahead of him and dragged one sandal. A seller weighed roots in a hanging pan while two men disputed his weights. Someone beat dust from a mat over a rail and earned a shout from the level beneath. Water ran in a channel cut through the centre of the floor.

No one looked upward as we came onto the stair. I had spent two years comparing tool marks, copied signs and the mineral residue on objects Sarah put before me. Below us a man mended a pot with wire. He held its broken halves between his knees, passed the wire through a drilled hole and turned the pot to reach the other side. His cup stood outside the circle of fragments at his feet.

At a table under three lamps, a baker pressed his thumb into rounds of dough, turned each one and pressed again. The evening bread reached us before we

crossed the centre of the stair: yeast, warm grain and the scorched flour at the edge of an oven. I knew charred cakes from sites nine thousand years old. I knew the pits in which the grain had been stored, the querns on which it had been broken and the changes in human bone after people began to eat it every day. The baker struck flour from his hands and called to a child to carry six loaves home.

The recorder knocked against the rail. Several faces lifted. Va-Sheva caught my sleeve before it struck again.

"They do not know," she said. "They will not learn it from you on a stair. Walk."

The child with the six loaves had stopped beneath us. One loaf slipped against his chest; he trapped it with his chin and laughed. I drew the machine close under my coat and walked. At the upper turn the stalls disappeared. The smell remained for twelve steps more.

The first blow took the stair sideways.

Stone struck my shoulder. The recorder drove into my ribs beneath my coat. A lamp went out below; another rolled in a yellow circle until a hand caught it. Then the sound arrived through the floor: one flat concussion, a single force driven into the Mountain without the patient interval of the five-stroke sounding. Dust fell from the joints overhead. Far inside the rock, worked stone ground against worked stone.

Sarah put both hands on the wall. "A charge. Down a shallow bore, close enough to break a void or test what breaks around it. North-west, near the surface. What lies there?"

Va-Sheva had turned toward the sound. She stood with the lamp held clear of the wall.

"What lies there?" Sarah repeated.

"Faith," Va-Sheva said. "A Faith passage. The road to the Hall."

She ran. Jean-Charles went with her and the nearest warden. Sarah called for a lamp, a plan of the north-western arc and the keeper of Stone. The ward children below had begun to cry. The seller's hanging scale knocked against its post with each movement underfoot.

Kailan put his palm to the wall. I put mine beside it. A tremor travelled through the stone, stopped, then returned deeper and slower. Grit moved under my fingers. From beyond the turn came a sharper failure and Va-Sheva shouting for the passage to be cleared.

I lifted the closed recorder toward the grinding and felt its motor through the case. A warden set his lamp beside Kailan and ran ahead. Kailan took it. We ran after the others.